

magazine



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IN KERALA, THE WORLD CUP IS PERSONAL

The FIFA World Cup is a homecoming here — of fan clubs, midnight screenings, bike rallies and WhatsApp groups that spring back to life every four years

Sandeep Menon

In late-90s Kerala, a young girl is jolted awake at night by the sound of the television. She finds her father watching football, a cup of tea in hand to stay awake. Soon, the cups become two as the World Cup turns into a way for her to connect with him. She watches a usually composed man move through a gamut of emotions – from euphoria to dejection. Around that time, she nails the Argentina flag to the mast.

Around the same period, a few hundred kilometres north, a young boy grows up playing pseudo shoot-outs with his father, who invokes the names of Diego Maradona, Gabriel

Batistuta and co. before every kick. Despite the prevalent Latin American flavour around him, the boy chooses England after Michael Owen’s solo goal in the 1998 World Cup. It becomes one of his earliest football memories; soon he begins following English football and its clubs.

Over the years, he also reads books about football culture in Argentina and becomes enamoured by the manic love, passion, mysticism and folklore surrounding the game, as well as its inspirational and mercurial footballers.

Years later, when the girl and boy meet and get married, their first point of agreement is their love for Argentine midfielder Juan Román Riquelme. When Argentina wins the World Cup,

the girl – now a woman – refuses to watch the shootout because, as any true fan will tell you, watching is precisely what brings bad luck. Ángel Di María, Emiliano Martínez, Lionel Messi et al. will never know of her – and countless others’ – sacrifices.

This is the story of my family. It is also just one among many in Kerala and other football-crazy regions of India: couples who met on Reddit football threads; parents and children, siblings and friends for whom the quadrennial FIFA World Cup becomes a month-long ritual of bonding; dormant WhatsApp groups reigniting the fading embers of friendship, briefly revived through football amid the exhaustion of everyday life.



The beautiful game (Clockwise from far left) Massive cutouts of international footballers in Kozhikode during past editions of the World Cup; a hoarding in Thiruvananthapuram; eager fans watching a live screening in Kerala; and a store in Mizoram’s Aizawl stocked with football merchandise. (AFP, S. RAMESH KURUP, PTI, MAHINSHA S. AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)

racks, along with flags and other merchandise. Electronics stores are bracing for swarms of customers looking to upgrade their TV sets, while satellite television subscriptions are expected to see a bump. Fan groups, from Kasaragod to Thiruvananthapuram, will organise celebratory bike rallies and, in the process, boost the business of local – often small – restaurants and cafes.

Massive cutouts of Messi and other footballing gods will loom over commuters on highways, in local marketplaces and street corners, even riverfronts. Maybe a size war will ensue, as it did in a tiny hamlet in Kozhikode back in 2022. Houses and compound walls will be painted in the colours of Brazil, Argentina and other footballing nations; vehicles too will be painted, only to be repainted once the World Cup ends.

Hair salons will bustle with requests for superstar hairstyles. “I became a Brazil fan around the 1998-2002 World Cups,” says Thrissur native and former Indian international defender Rino Anto. “Ronaldo was the star, and my friends sported his hairstyle – bald except for a patch in front. Hairstyles were always copied from the World Cup: [Roberto] Baggio, Ronaldo, [Paolo] Maldini, [Carlos] Tevez, and others. For the current generation, it’s mostly Cristiano [Ronaldo].”

Across towns and cities, World Cup screenings will be organised and temporary audience galleries erected; eateries will spring up to cater to hungry fans. Nearly 84 million people in India watched the last edition of the World Cup on television. The final alone drew 32 million viewers on the erstwhile JioCinema platform. That figure, surely, does not account for the mass screenings organised across the country.

Despite ongoing uncertainty over the telecast – India’s broadcast rights for the World Cup were awaiting final confirmation at the time of going to press – preparations are moving ahead, buoyed by optimism that everything will eventually fall into place. Meanwhile, less optimistic fans remain confident in their ability to find unofficial online streams to watch the matches.

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For the record

- For the first time, 48 teams will compete instead of 32, making this edition of the FIFA World Cup the biggest ever
- The tournament is being co-hosted by the United States, Canada and Mexico — the first World Cup hosted by three nations
- Mexico will become the first country ever to host the men’s World Cup three times (1970, 1986 and 2026)

With the tournament set to kick off on June 11, the celebratory wheels are slowly grinding into motion in Kerala. It is slightly delayed this time, knackered by the intense political wave that swept through the State during the recent Assembly elections.

Ongoing geopolitical tensions in many parts of the world, along with the World Cup’s placement in a less-than-ideal time zone (the tournament is spread across the U.S., Canada and Mexico) have also been raised as reasons by followers and fan clubs for the delayed build-up in the State.

The Messi economy
Perhaps it is just the new normal; in an age of information overload, instant

gratification, content saturation, and a relentless barrage of sporting events, it is unreasonable to expect a month-long build-up in news media or otherwise.

“The World Cup fever will kick in, there is no doubt, but just a bit closer to the event,” a worker at a sporting goods shop in Kozhikode confirms. Across the State, stores are stocking up on jerseys, flags, boots and balls in anticipation of the World Cup. Messi is the most in-demand shirt, it would seem, though Ronaldo is not far behind. The wait is on for the Messi economy – an unofficial, unaccountable financial outlay – to get underway.

Over the next few weeks, jersey replicas priced between ₹250 and ₹400 will fly off the



Sumana Mukherjee

As I turned the last page of Japanese author Asako Yuzuki's new novel *Hooked*, Indian social media was in an uproar over an Instagrammer by the name of Pujarini Pradhan (@lifeofpujaa). Based in rural West Bengal, she makes reels on literature and cinema, bringing up her son, wearing make-up, speaking four languages – frequently surprising and startling her close to 8 lakh followers with her feminism, perception and insight. Well, most of them, because some doubt her authenticity, insinuating she is “an industry plant”, wondering how a middle-class woman with heavily accented and grammatically incorrect English could possibly access Ray and Lynch and Premchand.

I have no unique take on Puja but the furore cut close to one of the primary themes of Yuzuki's *Hooked*, translated from the Japanese by Polly Barton. In the novel, Eriko Shimura, a high-achieving 30-year-old businesswoman, becomes obsessed with a blog titled ‘The Diary of Hallie B, The World's Worst Wife’.

To all appearances, it's an irrational fascination: Eriko, the only other woman in her large division in a Japanese multinational, has nothing in common with Shoko, the blogger, who revels in cheap food and slipshod laundry. But scratch a little deeper – and it is possible that in Hallie B/ Shoko, Eriko finds a tantalising glimpse of another way of life, removed from the pressures of quarterly targets and perfect performance assessments?

Facade of Japanese society
If Japanese fiction is having a moment in translation, much of the credit must go to a clutch of women writers and their genre-defying work. *Butter* (2017), Yuzuki's first work translated into English (also by Barton), was a blockbuster but writers such as Mieko Kawakami, Yoko Agawa, Banana Yoshimoto, Yoko Tawada have been consistently exploring themes of alienation, isolation, sexism, identity and technology from a peculiarly Japanese feminist perspective. *Butter* didn't work for me but, with *Hooked*, Yuzuki lays claim to this very select coterie of brilliance.

That said, it's difficult to appreciate *Hooked* (or, indeed, any of the writers mentioned above) without a certain understanding of Japanese society. On a recent visit, we found a stunningly functioning country: public transport is as clean as it is punctual, the food is as beautiful as it is delicious, the people are as courteous as they are efficient. But a little more every day, the façade disguises a deeply entrenched and all-powerful patriarchy that invisibilises women while thriving on their labour, holding them to impossible standards and actively disparaging and discouraging female solidarity.

That is why, when Eriko

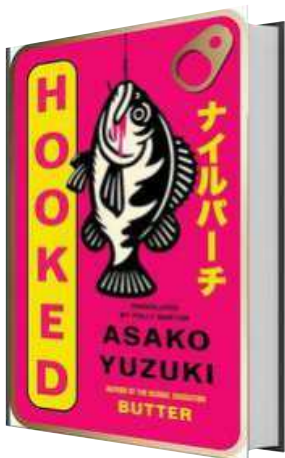
BETTER THAN BUTTER

In dissecting modern womanhood and the primal need for connection, Asako Yuzuki's *Hooked* cuts closer to the bone than her previous bestseller



tracks down Shoko, expecting friendship on the basis of her blogposts, it feels like a transgression. (It's worth noting that the Japanese original was published in 2015, when personal blogs were still a thing; though social media has changed rapidly since then, intimacy and consequent trust continue to be the currency, as evident in the @lifeofpujaa kerfuffle.)

Designed to compete
As the two women circle around each other in an ecosystem that will support them in their designated roles but bar any real



Hooked
Asako Yuzuki, trs Polly Barton
HarperCollins
₹699

bonding, Yuzuki draws parallels with the Nile perch, a carnivorous fish that destroyed the native fauna of Lake Victoria on release, and which Eriko is seeking to re-introduce to the Japanese table. Their desperate yet unnatural connection will see their lives and loves – always tenuous, barely treasured – spiral out of control. Who is Eriko, when she's not the perfect daughter, the perfect employee so venerated by Japanese society? And who is Shoko, if she finds

there's more to life than being a slob?

In a rare moment of lucidity, Eriko cuts to the quick: “Since I joined my company, it's been ingrained in me by the men there that women are stupid and don't know how to collaborate. Gradually... I came to believe what they were saying... The reason that women's competitiveness over minor issues... stops them from getting along even now isn't through any desire of their own. It's because society foists all these standards on us. The world we live in is specifically designed to make us compete.”

Dark and disturbing, provocative and intriguing, spiky and uneven (seriously, what is with the unrealised homoerotic thread in both novels?), *Hooked* looks at fractures and imbalances in picture-perfect Japanese society and is unafraid to hold it to account. And yes, it's better than *Butter*.

The reviewer is a Bengaluru-based writer and editor.

In her novel, Asako Yuzuki looks at fractures and imbalances in picture-perfect Japanese society; (below) the author. (GETTY IMAGES)



Mountain testament

Why this rich selection of folklore from the Himalayas is less a book and more a museum

Saikat Majumdar

How does one curate a museum? Does one display a cup or a cup on a plate? Is the cup-on-a-plate complete without the furniture on which it is meant to rest?

How do you situate the furniture without the room where it belongs? But how do you remove a room from the house, the house from the neighbourhood, the neighbourhood from the village or town... where does one stop and say, yes, this is where I sever the branch, this is all I need to evoke an image of the forest?

The question shadows *Voices in the Wind*, the richest collection of folktales, folklore and spirit stories from the Himalayas that I've come across, an anthology that is less a book and more a museum, holding echoes of lives, communities, and places that are impossible to contain within the jacket of a book.

That impossibility may be the great success of this collection. Some of the most memorable works of literature – some of the most moving lines, even – are those which evoke the intriguing failure to articulate that lies beyond words and thought. They are memorable due to their failure, dreamy in their vision and sweaty in their attempt. How does one collect voices in the wind in a printed text?

Hiding in the wilderness

Namita Gokhale and Malashri Lal's edited collection will remain invaluable as a work of reference shaped by nearly encyclopaedic ambitions, with the expansive Himalayan ranges divided into four parts: western, central, central-eastern and the north-eastern Himalayas, loaded by tales of varying length and provenance from a plenitude of places: Jammu, Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh, to Assam, Manipur, Meghalaya. But how does the whispering breath of trees, animals, spirits and lost people come to walk the visible plains of private readership, and that too in English?

Memorable, achingly articulate woodcut illustrations by Assamese artist Nalinakshya Talukdar on almost every page evoke moments from the lores and myths that find new, oddly modern lives in written prose below them.

There are moments when the distant-but-deeply remembered music of

a lost world animates a shocking aesthetic. Such is the action of a brutal brother – in the folklore ‘A Pomegranate Bud’ from Jammu – who spares “not a second to slash and decapitate his sister”. As he dyes an *odhni* with the blood he needs from her body, we are told that, “His hands were too quick to have mercy on his sister, his love too little.”

But sometimes, the blood, even when spilled to save the one born of it, remains heartbreakingly cold – the throbbing of life and love behind it inaudible, almost cruelly impersonal on paper. In the Ladakh tale ‘Amo-Dalmo Ju: The Story of an Ibex Mother’, the mother goat is killed by a hunter in the presence of her kid. In effort to spare her child the terror, the mother remains in denial of her injury till the last moment, pretending it to be a minor accident, till the arrival of the hideous final moment: “After a while he stopped to check if his mother was following him. He saw the hunter cutting her throat ruthlessly. Her blood was flooding out and her legs fluttering in the tight grip of the hunter. It was a horrible sight, and he ran away in the wilderness with all his might.”

Tied to nature

Oral myths have cadences of their own. They are also loaded with strong feelings around birth and death, love, hope, greed and betrayal. Do they echo through English prose the way they roll through woods, valleys and hills?

What about the grief of the *sasu* – in the Himachali tale ‘Suspensions’ – who kills her *bahu* on the suspicion that the younger woman is shirking work, only to realise her innocence later. How does the grief of her fatal mistake make the mother-in-law withdraw “from the world”? Her decline follows the rhythm of harvest: “The festive echoes of Lohri dulled into morning. And quietly, without ceremony or song, the *sasu* too passed away, withered by sorrow, hollowed by her own hand.”

Grief, loss and death, in these myths, melt into nature, like the seven-hued head cloth of the noble King Rhaum that lived on after his betrayal by his friend King Rabbh in the Assam tale ‘How the Rainbow Came to Be’. These windblown myths will live with us in the shape of an alien entity – a book.

The reviewer is the author, most recently of Open Intelligence: Education Between Art and Artificial.



Voices in the Wind
Ed. Namita Gokhale and Malashri Lal
Penguin
₹999

Ghosts of Kashmir

This debut work resurrects the pain, memory and resilience of conflict-torn lives

Bilal Gani

When Jammu and Kashmir's special constitutional position was rescinded and the political map of the erstwhile state was redrawn in August 2019, it was as if an epitaph had been inscribed on the new map: “Here lies Naya Kashmir – renewed in hope, united in destiny. From valleys of silence rise voices of progress, peace and possibility. Its mountains now echo with dreams carried forward by every new generation.”

In *The Man from Kashmir*, Muddasir

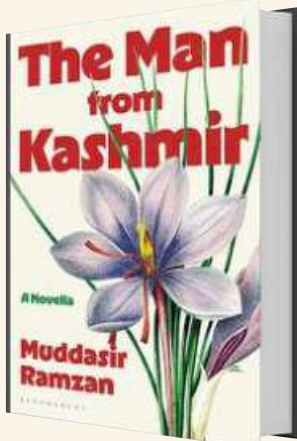
Ramzan erases that epitaph and brings back to life the old Kashmir of oppressed, traumatic and war-torn lives. Through a soul-stirring and heartbreaking account of suffering, grief and loss, Ramzan resurrects memories of a destructive conflict and its brutal intrusion into human life. The characters are ordinary people terrified by an extraordinary and bloody war.

Set in Kashmir Valley in the 1990s, this novella of connected stories follows the fortunes of two local families – one Muslim and the other Hindu. Ayesha, who eloped with a man and now lives separated from her in-laws,

gives birth in a packed mosque where the entire town of Poshmarg has sought refuge following a militant attack on a nearby army camp. It is both a moment of beauty and brutality. While Ayesha and her husband Gul prepare a feast to welcome their son, other residents prepare to leave town because it is no longer safe.

Lives under siege

In another story, Ram, Lalita's beloved husband, is shot dead by an unidentified gunman after cheering for the Indian cricket team during an India-West Indies match in Srinagar, even as the stadium erupts with



The Man from Kashmir
Muddasir Ramzan
Bloomsbury
₹499

The novella is set in Kashmir Valley in the 90s. (GETTY IMAGES)

slogans against them. Later, Ram's friend Gul is also killed when he tries to go after the perpetrators after Lalita receives news of her

husband's death.

Elsewhere, Farooq, Ayesha's brother, encounters a wild man in a forest who narrates a story about his transformation from a god-fearing individual into a haunted outcast – a tale that echoes Kashmir's ghost stories of witches and fear during the height of the insurgency.

In these haunting narratives, Ramzan acquaints readers with people who live precarious lives amidst intense political conflict. The book is a distressing study of a city and culture under siege from more than one occupying force. *The Man from Kashmir* is a poignant debut that captures the hidden struggles and quiet resilience of Kashmir's people with rare empathy, emotional depth and grace.

The reviewer is an academic and literary critic based in Kashmir.



(Clockwise from left) Nobel laureates Har Gobind Khorana, Subrahmanyam Chandrasekhar, Abhijit Banerjee and Venkatraman Ramakrishnan. (GETTY IMAGES)

Vasudevan Mukunth
mukunth.v@thehindu.co.in

A *Touch of Genius*, a new anthology of the writings of “Indian Nobel laureates”, edited by historian Rudrangshu Mukherjee, is both nationalist and critical of nationalism – possibly by accident – and exists in an unresolved tension with itself.

But first, Mukherjee’s introduction is absorbing. His use of Isaiah Berlin’s distinction between the hedgehog and the fox to argue that ‘genius’ is that which resists disciplinary pigeonholing is insightful. The intellectual connections he traces between some of the laureates also give the collection a coherence it might otherwise lack.

Risking genetic essentialism

Now, four of the book’s Nobel laureates – Har Gobind Khorana, Subrahmanyam Chandrasekhar, Venkatraman Ramakrishnan and Abhijit Banerjee – won the prize for work they did outside India. None of them were Indian citizens for most of their lives. What makes them or their work “Indian”? When the media addresses these individuals as “Indian Nobel laureates”, the narratives risk celebrating genetic essentialism: the notion that India can claim their work because they share their genes with Indian ones at a population level.

Chandrasekhar did all his most important work when he was at the University of Chicago. Khorana conducted his prize-winning work on the genetic code in the U.S. and Canada. Ramakrishnan did his work on ribosomes at the University of Cambridge. Banerjee has lived and worked in the U.S. for decades now.

If anything, these individuals could be, or could have been, ‘Indian’ because they were moulded by Indian educational and cultural environments before they left. In a conversation with the American physicist Spencer Weart included in the book, Chandrasekhar says C.V. Raman’s discovery had a “big impact” on him. Ramakrishnan grew up in Tamil Nadu and Banerjee’s parents were both Indian economists. It is hard to

A book on writings by Indian Nobel laureates could expand minds only if readers question its idea of ‘Indian genius’

WHOSE
BRILLIANCE
IS IT ANYWAY?

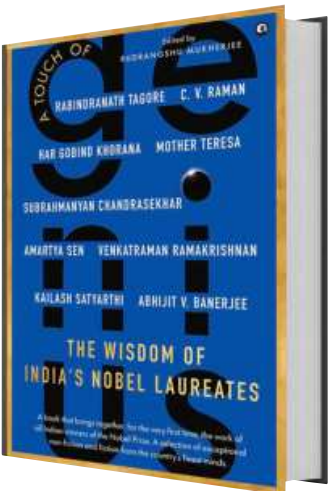
say where intellectual formation happens.

However, that doesn’t meaningfully make their work ‘Indian’. In fact, the label is best applied to Amartya Sen, Rabindranath Tagore and Raman. Sen’s intellectual preoccupations are about India per se. Tagore and Raman worked in India, for Indian institutions, on problems they encountered in India.

The curation omits these distinctions, however. Many of these laureates left India partly because the scientific and institutional infrastructure of their time could not support their work. If a laureate has not toiled in Indian conditions, including those particular to the country pre-liberalisation – from chronic underfunding to the concentration of institutional power in individual figures – the label only has the counterproductive genealogical meaning.

A Nobel Prize certifies achievement in a particular domain over particular criteria at a particular historical moment. It says nothing about the laureate’s broader wisdom. Yes, these individuals possess the material and reputational freedom to think in public without immediate professional consequences. The range of writing in the book is also remarkable: it has a physicist

Mukherjee’s introduction is absorbing. His use of Isaiah Berlin’s distinction between the hedgehog and the fox to argue that ‘genius’ is that which resists disciplinary pigeonholing is insightful.



A Touch of Genius: The Wisdom of India’s Nobel Laureates
Ed. Rudrangshu Mukherjee
Aleph Book Company
₹1,499

writing on beauty, an economist on Bengal’s rivers, and a molecular biologist on mortality. But the prize confers no special authority here: wisdom belongs to anyone, Nobel Prize or no.

Beyond the nation

Indeed, if we could set aside the luminance of its authors, *A Touch of Genius* seems like a showcase of scientific humanism, often delivered in contrasting voices. Raman’s prose is a relic of a more romantic era of discovery as he imbues the physical world with a sense of Victorian wonder. Ramakrishnan, on the other hand, offers a conversational and witty voice, and in the process manages to reveal himself to be human, not institution.

Chandrasekhar wields a sophisticated diction as he looks for beauty in “King Lear,

the Missa Solemnis, and the Principia” while Kailash Satyarthi eschews academic distance for the emotional testimonial, focusing on the “blackened feet” of a desperate father or the “cool sunlight” a rescued child feels. Together with Khorana’s modesty and Banerjee’s slightly irreverent scepticism, the collection proves the laureates’ ability to command the English language was essential to making their specialised “geniuses” a public legacy.

Having assembled such a remarkable portrait, the anthology strains to bend it into a smaller, stiffer frame. Simply, you cannot use Tagore – the book’s most voluminous contributor – to make an argument for Indian greatness without sawing off the branch you are sitting on.

Likewise, Sen describes democracy as a universal value and his essays insist on the importance of reasoning and individual capability over any collective identity. The position is fundamentally anti-essentialist. Mother Teresa’s writings are also about Christ, love, and the soul; her theology or ethics are not Indian because they belong to the global history of the Catholic Church, rooted in a Christo-centric worldview indifferent to the book’s nationalist enclosure.

In the end, *A Touch of Genius* is perplexing because its two characters are at odds with each other. It could be a chance for readers to expand their minds but only if they also ask tough questions about what the ‘genius’ in its pages really has to do with India.

What journeys
can and cannot teach us

In her latest book, Pallavi Aiyar asserts that moving across cultures becomes transformative only if it is accompanied by reflection

Sukhada Tatke

In one of his letters to Lucilius, the Stoic philosopher Seneca addresses the subject of travel. He posits that travel to new and distant places cannot be a remedy for inner anxiety or restlessness. To drive home this point, he invokes Socrates: “Why do you wonder that globetrotting does not help you, seeing that you always take yourself with you? The reason which set you wandering is ever at your heels.”

The central claim

Several centuries later, Pallavi Aiyar makes a competent rebuttal in her latest book, which blends memoir and travel writing with journalistic rigour and curiosity. *Travels in the Other Place: Pursuing the Self in Eight Acts* asserts that travel is not inherently transformative; it becomes so only if accompanied by reflection.

“Travelling elsewhere has the counterintuitive effect of waking the traveller up to themselves – of seeing themselves more clearly because of the comparative framework they now have,” Aiyar writes. This is the central claim of the book. Our ability to see ourselves clearly also throws others into sharp relief.

Aiyar writes from experience. She has made a career as a foreign correspondent, not out of choice but circumstance. It was education that first took Aiyar to London as a student. There she met a Spaniard, who later became her husband. With him, she moved from country to country, gathering experiences and wisdom along the way, which she sprinkles liberally across the book. For over three decades, Aiyar has lived in nine countries across Asia and Europe. She blurs the line between travelling and living. To build and rebuild a life across cultures and languages, even as a resident, is a form of travel which requires navigating unfamiliar landscapes and terrains.

The book unfolds in eight essays with pithy and straightforward titles such as ‘Books, Illness, Reporting, Hair...’ Like all memoirs, the encounters are rooted in Aiyar’s own life. Like all good memoirs, the encounters that begin with herself extend outward to land on larger historical and cultural sweeps of understanding. This is what makes them relatable. Her eyes become our eyes; what she hears and feels, we hear and feel too.

We travel through her childhood fascination and love for books, as well as her adult days of reporting in foreign lands. We journey alongside her as she experiences motherhood, cancer and the grief of losing her mother.

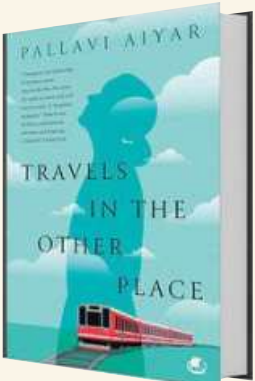
At the heart of the assumption that travel broadens horizons is the fundamental question: who gets to travel? The immersive kind of travel is born out of great privilege. “Choosing

cosmopolitanism over patriotism is not always, or simply, a matter of making the more virtuous choice. It is at least as much about being lucky. About birth. About caste. About language. About passports,” she writes.

This dichotomy between cosmopolitanism and patriotism, however, is at odds with the current geopolitical landscape. A rise in disposable incomes has meant that people are travelling further afield than they ever did. At the same time, the world has become engulfed by xenophobia and ethnonationalism. There is no direct causation or co-relation, but if we carry a fixed, unchanging mind map, no amount of travel can stretch it enough for us.

Aiyar illustrates how engaging with another culture requires both a desire and humility, by providing details of her everyday life: her language missteps, her annoyances and delights, her ability to laugh at herself. In Spain, she orders advocates in restaurants instead of avocados; in China, she asks for soup and gets sugar instead because of her botched-up pronunciation.

No place is perfect but if you look close enough, she says, every place has something to offer. Brussels was boring but had fabulous farmers’ markets. Jakarta’s traffic was a nightmare, but the people were lovely.



Travels in the Other Place: Pursuing the Self in Eight Acts
Pallavi Aiyar
Tranquebar
₹599

The toughest moments

But it’s impossible to always put a positive spin on travel. Susan Sontag’s *Illness as Metaphor* talks about the kingdom of the well and the kingdom of the sick, and sooner or later, she says, each one of us will have to “identify ourselves as citizens of that other place”. It is this other place that Aiyar takes us to in affecting essays on illness and grief. This is where she is at her best, unflinching in her vulnerability and portrayal of

the ugliness with which we humans come undone.

Using the language of travel in the toughest moments of life, Aiyar seems to be saying, they, too, like all travels, will one day end. She refers to “the kingdom of Cancer” as a “terrain of high mountains, deep troughs, and even some wildflower-carpeted valleys... And often, just when you think you’re cresting the summit, you realise the actual peak has been shrouded in mist.”

Ultimately, her views are not all that different from Seneca’s. We do carry ourselves on our travels. Travel is not romantic; it has its limits. It can illuminate but not replace introspection.

At its best, travel offers us the opportunity to challenge what we think we know best. In a world beset by intolerance and prejudice, where mobility and hardened borders co-exist, that seemingly modest claim is much needed.

The reviewer is a writer and reporter based in Edinburgh. She writes on books, culture, immigration and history.



GETTY IMAGES / ISTOCK

BROWSER

Chand Bibi: The Lives and Legends of a Warrior Queen

Sarah Waheed
Juggernaut
₹899

A cultural historian explores the life of the 16th-century Deccani queen regent Chand Bibi, a formidable Muslim warrior who defeated the most powerful forces of her time: Mughal imperial armies.



Homes Without Windows

Chandu Maheria, trs. Hemang Ashwinkumar
Juggernaut
₹699

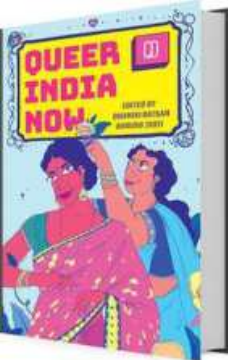
Maheria gives a peek into his journey from grinding poverty in the working-class chawls of east Ahmedabad to a life of reading, writing, and political struggle. This is Maheria’s first translation in English.



Queer India Now

Ed. Dhamini Ratnam and Dhruvo Jyoti
Queer Directions
₹499

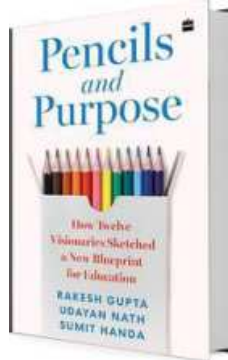
This anthology is a collection of essays and testimonies from various voices on the LGBTQIA+ spectrum. It offers to show what it means to live as a queer person in a society that remains legally restrictive and socially unaccommodating.



Pencils and Purpose

Rakesh Gupta, Udayan Nath, Sumit Handa
HarperCollins India
₹599

Through the personal stories, decisions, leadership styles and life lessons of school founders, edtech innovators and others, this book sheds light on leaders who have dedicated their lives to elevating India’s educational landscape.



CONTINUED FROM
PAGE 1

A social revolution
The social impact of the FIFA World Cup in Kerala over the decades is perhaps even more significant. For many, especially in the past when access to information and higher education was far more limited, the tournament became a window to the wider world. Kerala's enduring affection for Brazil and Argentina – the former, in particular, having a longer legacy in the state – emerged partly from political and cultural narratives shaped by Left-leaning, anti-imperial and anti-establishment sentiments, however romanticised or historically imprecise some of those associations may have been over time.

People came to know the Netherlands through Johan Cruyff and the tactical beauty of 'Total Football', a style of play in which players constantly switched positions and attacked as a unit. Germany arrived through the dominance of Gerd Müller and Franz Beckenbauer. Italy, Croatia and other European nations too slowly entered the Malayali imagination through football, long before globalisation and the Internet collapsed distances between worlds.

"Everyone, even those without formal education, knows about countries and flags from around the world

through football," says K.M. Narendran, author and journalist, formerly with All India Radio. "People wear jerseys, get to know the players and learn about the history and culture of these countries through the stories and reports published around the World Cup. It is an education that arrives every four years."



I became a Brazil fan around the 1998-2002 World Cups. Ronaldo was the star, and my friends sported his hairstyle – bald except for a patch in front. Hairstyles were always copied from the World Cup. Baggio, Ronaldo, Maldini, Tevez, and others. For the current generation, it's mostly Cristiano [Ronaldo]

RINO ANTO
Former Indian international defender

IN KERALA, THE WORLD CUP IS PERSONAL



With the evolution of broadcasting, a fan culture once heavily skewed towards Latin American teams has gradually expanded to embrace European sides as well, though the former still command the largest following. Fan clubs for European teams began to flourish around the turn of the millennium, driven by their World Cup dominance, the proliferation of televised league matches, and the rise of football video games on computers and consoles.

These fan clubs are secular beasts. During the World Cup, all differences are forgotten; political rivalry is set aside as people unite under the colours of their favourite teams. For the third consecutive World Cup, the Janakiya Samidhi, Puthiyapalam, a local collective in Kozhikode comprising members from across political parties, is building a screening gallery with a seating capacity of over 2,000, with support from the local community.

"There are no political or

religious divisions here," says Shiras Khan, one of the leaders of the collective. "It is very inclusive. We will also have cultural programmes, penalty shoot-out competitions, a food court and so on, because we want to ensure that women and children can also be part of the World Cup festivities." Funds for the initiative have been raised through the sale of firecrackers during Vishu by one of the collective's licensed members, as well as through calendars and chili funds.

Bonding in the time of trauma
Even as Kerala gears up, the rest of the country too is slowly gathering momentum. Plans are underway for community screenings in Shillong, Kolkata, Goa and Bengaluru, among other cities. In Mizoram, stores have stocked up on jerseys as the tournament draws near.

"The interest is now starting to grow," says a local football club administrator in Aizawl. Meanwhile, Kolkata – still

FIFA five
● The tournament has mascots representing each host country: Maple the moose (Canada); Zayu the jaguar (Mexico); Clutch the bald eagle (U.S.)
● Italy will miss the World Cup for the third consecutive time after failing to qualify. An entire generation has not watched the four-time champions play the World Cup
● The World Cup final will feature a Super Bowl-style

half-time show, a departure from the traditional 15-minute half-time break
● Experts have warned that some matches may be played in dangerous summer heat conditions, especially in cities like Miami and Kansas City
● Since the tournament spans all of North America, some teams could travel thousands of kilometres between matches, raising questions about how travel and heat could affect player fitness

(Clockwise from above) A fan poses with the FIFA World Cup Trophy in Guwahati; football fans in Kerala's Malappuram; and a roadside stall selling jerseys in Kolkata. (GETTY IMAGES AND SAKHEER HUSSAIN)

reeling from the violence that followed last month's West Bengal Assembly Election results – is gradually preparing to welcome the World Cup. "The flags at the moment are still those of political parties, but they will soon give way to those of Brazil, Argentina and others," says actor Durbur Sharma, who hails from Ganguly Bagan in South Kolkata.

Four years ago, Sharma spent the night of Argentina's World Cup victory dancing in the streets with fellow fans. "It was just fantastic. It came after so many years of disappointment, of being mocked by friends. I even had an argument with my grandfather, who was rooting



People are crazy for football in Manipur. Even though tensions remain high in the State, people will still turn up for match screenings
RENEDEY SINGH
Former Indian midfielder

GREEN HUMOUR

Rohan Chakravarty

CRITICIZE THEM ALL YOU WANT BUT YOU CAN'T DENY THAT THIS GOVERNMENT CONSISTENTLY DELIVERS FAR MORE THAN IT PROMISES!



Saibal Chatterjee

The lessons of 1968, when Nouvelle Vague (French New Wave) directors such as Jean-Luc Godard, echoing the leftist student protests sweeping the nation, brought the Cannes Film Festival to a halt on its ninth day, have stood the organisers in good stead. The world's premier film festival has since perfected the art of embracing politics without letting agent provocateurs scuttle the event.

This year, the Cannes balancing act unfolded subliminally. Paul Laverty, best known for collaborations with English director Ken Loach, set the tone at the 79th edition's opening jury press conference. The Kolkata-born Scottish screenwriter, a member of the main Competition jury led by Korean filmmaker Park Chan-wook, ripped into Hollywood for boycotting actors such as Susan Sarandon, Javier Bardem and Mark Ruffalo for their stance on Israel's hostilities in Gaza.

HOW CANNES NAVIGATES POLITICS

The film festival has perfected the art of embracing differences without letting agent provocateurs scuttle the event



takes courage to talk about what people really see."

Gaza was missing at La Croisette
On the last day (May 23), several stirring speeches, from Canadian filmmaker Xavier Dolan quoting Palestinian author Mahmoud Darwish, to Lebanese actor-director Nadine Labaki lamenting Lebanon's travails, rang down the curtain on a festival that had no dearth of 'political' cinema. Many either directly addressed or tangentially alluded to the Ukraine war (Japanese director Koji Fukada's *Nagi Notes* and French filmmaker Charline Bourgeois-Tacquet's *A Woman's Life*), and at least one (French director Arthur Harari's *The Unknown*) took a swipe at U.S. President Donald Trump. What

was missing, however, was any mention of Gaza – not even in the Un Certain Regard title, *Yesterday the Eye Didn't Sleep*, an understated film by Palestinian diaspora filmmaker Rakan Mayasi.

"Gaza isn't mentioned [as often as Iran or Ukraine] in contemporary world cinema because everybody is wary of

The power of Fjord lies in the human story that the director locates in his dissection of systems of law and religious dogma

TUDOR VLADIMIR PANDURU
Director of photography, *Fjord*



falling foul of the funding system," says Tareq Khalaf, the Ramallah-based filmmaker, architect and cultural activist. Khalaf, who was in Cannes to pitch his first feature, *Azziza: In a Cherished Land*, adds that the Palestine Pavilion at Cannes was "a safe space for those of us who

Hollywood's absence explained

The non-appearance of Hollywood blockbusters this year had more to do with commerce than politics. Apart from the high cost of a splashy premiere on the French Riviera, Hollywood majors are also increasingly wary of negative reviews by the international press corps, which can jeopardise box-office prospects. So, Steven Spielberg's *Disclosure Day* and Christopher Nolan's *The Odyssey*, both scheduled for release within weeks of the festival, stayed away.

want to tell our stories, resist the erasure of memory and look for support for our projects."

The pavilion, organised by the Palestine Film Institute, had about 40 filmmakers and producers in attendance. Among them was Germany-based Palestinian-Syrian filmmaker Abdallah Al-Khatib. His *Chronicles from the Siege* won the Best First Feature award earlier this year at the Berlinale, where he had used the opportunity to launch a broadside against Israel for the Gaza atrocities and the German government for its complicity. His speech nearly cut short festive director Tricia Tuttle's tenure. But the feisty young filmmaker has no regrets. "I said what I had to," he says. "I gave it to them."

No place for Israeli films
Cannes operates in far more controlled ways than other film festivals. Significantly, since the events of October 7, 2023, when Palestinian militant group Hamas attacked Israel, it has not programmed a single Israeli film in Competition or Un Certain Regard.

Last year, Israel director Nadav Lapid's biting political satire *Yes!* – about a Tel Aviv-based jazz musician who accepts a commission to compose a new national anthem with belligerent lyrics to capture the nation's post-October 7 mood – was relegated to the Directors' Fortnight, an independent sidebar

at the film festival. At the same time, actor Juliette Binoche's jury awarded the Palme d'Or to Iranian dissident filmmaker Jafar Panahi's *It Was Just an Accident*, which is a critique of all authoritarian regimes.

This year, too, Russian director Andrey Zvyagintsev's masterfully crafted *Moscow*, a crime drama that calls out Putin's Russia, was tipped to win for reasons both political and artistic. It did not. In a surprise decision, the jury favoured *Fjord*, Romanian filmmaker Cristian Mungiu's first film, shot entirely outside the country and, as he said in his speech, "a commitment against all forms of fundamentalism".

It centres on a conservative Romanian-Norwegian couple who collides with Norway's stringent child protection system because of their religion-driven parenting. The film's director of photography, Tudor Vladimír Panduru, tells me, "The power of *Fjord* lies in the human story that the director locates in his dissection of systems of law and religious dogma."

Standing up for the oppressed
Cannes does not seek disruptive change; it pursues it through dribbles. For instance, last year, the festival's official selection had a Palestinian film: directors Tarzan and Arab Nasser's *Once Upon a Time in Gaza*. It won the Un Certain Regard Prize. In the ACID sidebar, Iranian filmmaker Sepideh Farsi's documentary, *Put Your Soul on Your Hands and Walk*, occasioned a moving tribute from Binoche to slain Gazan photojournalist Fatima Hassouna.

The actor was also at the centre of attention way back in 2010 as a Competition jury member. Binoche held up a banner with Panahi's name at the closing ceremony to acknowledge the absence of the Iranian director. He had been named a juror, but Tehran barred him from travelling. So, Cannes prominently displayed an empty chair at every jury meeting and event as a sign of protest.

Filmmaker Mohammad Rasoulof faced a similar situation more recently. His film, *The Seed of the Sacred Fig*, was in Competition in 2024. The selection led to Rasoulof being sentenced to eight years in prison for "propaganda against the regime". He and a few crew members managed to flee Iran and attend the film's premiere on the festival's penultimate day.

In Cannes, the show goes on no matter what. The year Godard had his way was an aberration.

The writer is a New Delhi-based film critic.

Dear friends, since you are reading this column, I have no doubt at all that you are firmly in the top 1% of all intellectual consumers of news and information in the country. You are a discerning connoisseur of current affairs. Which is why I am certain you have read all the great classics, including *The Count of Monte Cristo* in the original Malayalam version, as I have.

This is also why I am sure most of you have read the Constitution of India from cover to cover, and therefore you are all well aware that India is a Union of States. And there are many States. And the people of all these States are equally unbearable. Especially the people of your own State because you can actually understand the nonsense they are saying.

Do I know what people are saying in Konkani, Marathi or Kashmiri? No. But I am sure it is all unbearable. In today's dispatch, I wish to highlight one huge issue that is now becoming unavoidable in modern discourse. Let me explain with the example of a recent unbearable shenanigan.

I was at an ice-cream parlour, in a corner of the suburb of London I call home, with my children, procuring some frozen confections for the family. Nearby, there was another family that appeared vaguely South Asian, also eating ice-cold puddings. The father nodded at me. I nodded back with the standard international South-Asian solidarity that conveys the message: "Hello, my brother in colonial legacy. I hope you are doing okay. I am also doing okay. Please do not talk to me. Unless there is some emergency, in which case please feel free."

Sometime later, having partaken of our ice creams, we got up to leave at the exact same time as the other family. On emerging from the shop, the father said: "So, are you also from India?" I said yes! So nice to meet you!

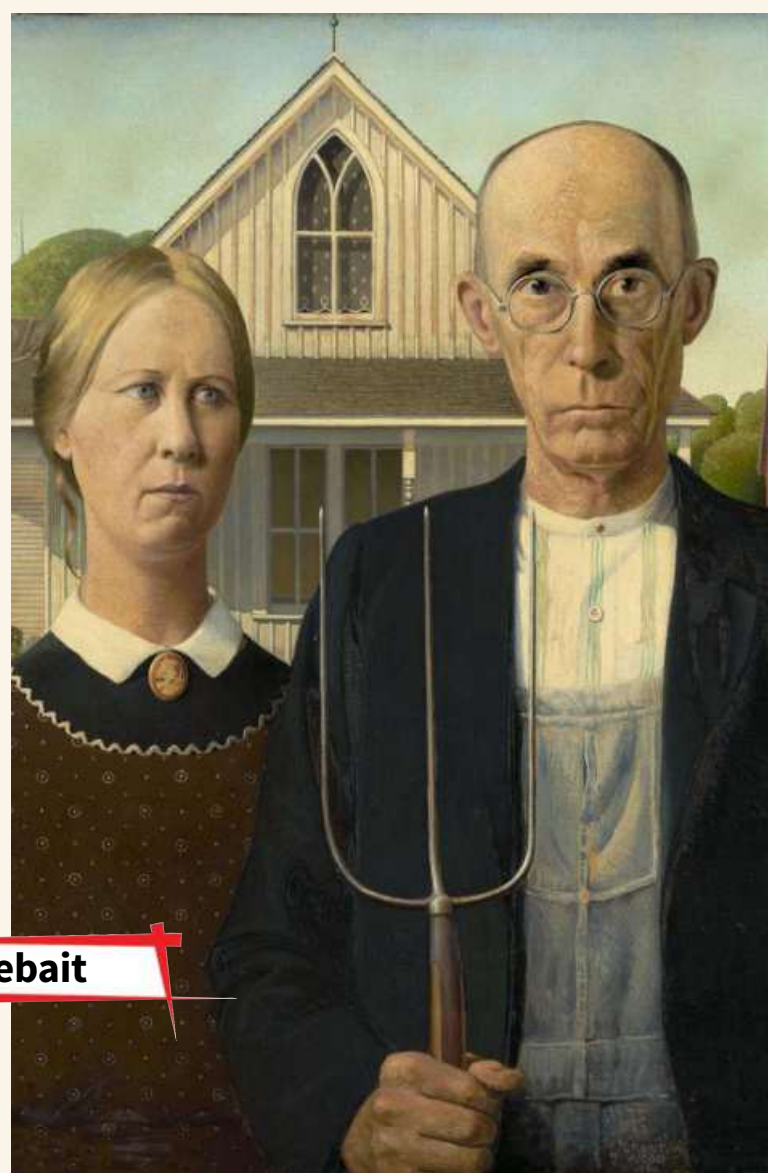
Are you South Indian, he asked. Yes, I said, from Kerala.

And then this guy said: "So, what do Malayalis think about Narendra Modi?"

Friends, some pertinent points: I have never met this person before. I repeat, I have never met this person before. I have not, and let me say this unequivocally, met this person before.

I laughed and made a joke about how everywhere in the world you go, you will meet one

TRICKTIONARY EPISODE 31
Please leave me alone
Random people hijack me into conversations about Indian politics in supermarkets, airports, PTA meetings



Malayali. Ha ha ha. So funny. Please leave me alone. And then this guy said: "So, what do Malayalis think about Narendra Modi?"

As if I am the Chairman and Managing Director of Kerala.

It took another 10 minutes of absolutely painful conversation before I told the man that I am feeling a lot of pain in my back, it could be a kidney stone, I would now like to go to the nearest hospital. He said, "Oh no, I hope it

is not serious. Also, why do Malayalis go to the Gulf?" Dear readers in general, and overseas Indian people in particular, please do not do this. Perhaps you spend your entire day consuming news nonstop, and your entire life is dedicated to engaging with other Indian people through the prism of politics. But some of us just want to have ice cream with our family.

Also, we have our own special place for discussing

politics: school alumni WhatsApp group, college alumni WhatsApp group, MBA alumni WhatsApp group, secret college alumni WhatsApp group excluding three unbearable fellows, secret college alumni WhatsApp group excluding previous three unbearable fellows and two more fellows who became unbearable more recently, family WhatsApp group, and awkward family events such as Onam, Christmas, Vishu, Iftar, etc.

Already, I have an abundant number of opportunities to develop deep hatred for close family and friends. Currently, I do not have any need to hate random members of the public as well.

In fact, I think it is time we came up with a word for this phenomenon where random people will hijack you in supermarkets, airports, PTA meetings etc., and bait you into a

conversation about Indian politics. If we give it a name, then maybe it will become easier to stop this reprehensible practice. And that word is: **debat**.

Example sentence: "After being debated for the fifth time that week by random strangers demanding she explain 'what Bengalis think about everything', Ananya started telling people she was born and brought up in Sao Tome and Principe just to avoid the conversation."

Are you too the victim of drive-by debating? How did you extricate yourself from this situation? Please help.

Sidin Vadukut helps early stage companies communicate better. He blogs at www.whatay.com.

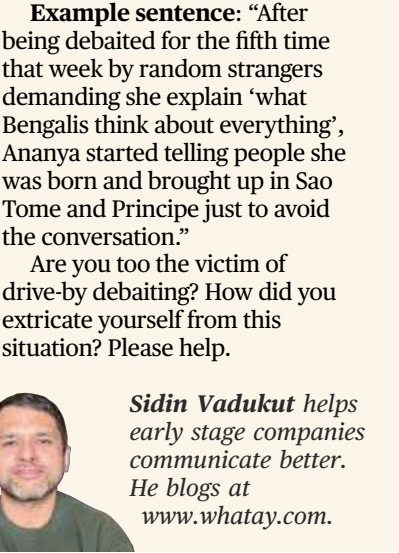




ILLUSTRATION: ZAINAB TAMBAWALLA

A LITTLE LIFE WHEN A NUN AND A SEER BECAME FRIENDS

They never knocked heads over religion, and always made time for *haerseh* and *kehwe*

It was a warm, bright day in early April. After a heavy breakfast, I found myself unable to move. Phuphee had fed everyone, including Maetonji, her friend and a nun who ran the local missionary hospital, generous portions of *haerseh*. She'd been preparing the slow-cooked mutton delicacy since yesterday's breakfast. Phuphee would make *haerseh* (or *hareesa*) in the winter and early spring, and for as long as I could remember, Maetonji would be present when she made it. Like that morning's breakfast. After she had washed the food down with a cup of hot *kehwe*, she looked at Phuphee and said, 'Ta-heee-ra, may Jesus bless your hands for making such wonderful *haerseh* for us all. You may have to get Ramzaana [a local *tanga waala*] to bring his cart and a rope to get me to move.'

'Thav waen, tche kyoath pyoont akh [leave it, you ate so little],' replied Phuphee, smiling at her friend. 'Bae dimai thoda syieth [I will give you a little to take with you].'

'Now, now, Ta-heee-ra, we both know that's not true. If I don't eat for the rest of the week, I think I shall be perfectly alright. But I shan't say no to your offer,' said Maetonji, winking

at Phuphee. An hour or so later, I had, with great effort, managed to move my person from the kitchen to the verandah, where I had plopped onto

a couple of cushions. From my supine position, I could see Phuphee and Maetonji sitting by a freshly dug flower bed. They were planting tulip bulbs. I watched them as they talked, joked and worked together. Every few minutes, they would break into peals of laughter and then one would poke the other to start working again. It was wonderful watching these two women together. As far as I could remember, Maetonji and Phuphee had been together. I had never known one without the other. Though they were in their 60s now – one in her *pheran* and scarf, and the other in her black and white habit – I could very easily imagine them as school girls, holding hands, running around, playing their girlhood games. They were not the likeliest of friends. I had heard from others in the village that they had met four decades ago. Just a few months after Phuphee got married, Maetonji had arrived to set up the local clinic. They had met when Phuphee was expecting her first child and had severe morning sickness. Having found no relief with the local herbalist, and on advice from her maternal grandmother, she had gone to see Sister Gabriella, or Maetonji as she would come to be known in the village. They had an instant connection. I have always wondered what had brought them together and how they had made it through the trials and tribulations of life while navigating such different lives, such different faiths. It was a question I often asked Phuphee, to which she would reply, 'You need to ask Maetonji.' When I asked Maetonji, she would reply, 'You need to ask Ta-heee-ra.' They climbed up the steps to the

verandah and sat down beside me. It seemed like an excellent opportunity to ask the questions they always evaded. 'Well, child,' said Maetonji, 'it was her cooking. I tasted her *haerseh* and knew I had to keep her close,' and burst out laughing. 'Gub-reeela, *asye paezyi amyis poz dapun* [Gabriella, we should tell her the truth],' said Phuphee rather solemnly, but I could see laughter straining at the corners of her lips. Maetonji sat up, trying her best to be serious, and said, 'Well, we became great friends when I stopped trying to convert Ta-heee-ra to Christianity and she stopped trying to turn me into a Muslim.' 'Though, to be honest,' Phuphee interrupted, 'the idea of having to [as a nun] spend one's entire life without a man did entice me somewhat.' And she laughed. It was impossible to get an answer out of them, so I gave up. Instead, I watched as they helped themselves to cups of *kehwe* from the samovar and went back into the garden to plant tulip bulbs. Watching them reminded me of something I had witnessed years ago, at the seaside. On a calm, beautiful day, I had been mesmerised by the rhythmic ebb and flow of waves gently washing up on the shore. So it was with these two. Like the sea and the shore, they existed individually, but together they made more sense. Maybe that's what friendship was: making sense to each other.



Saba Mahjoor, a Kashmiri living in England, spends her scant free time contemplating life's vagaries.

GOREN BRIDGE Polish ingenuity Neither vulnerable, South deals

Bob Jones

South in today's deal was Polish World Champion Katarzyna Dufurat. She found herself in a poor slam after a highly competitive auction that forced North to make a key decision at a high level. North made the aggressive choice and now Dufurat had to play it.

She won the opening heart lead with her ace and led a club to dummy's 10. This won, but East's discard on the ace of clubs was a disappointment. West's opening heart lead was certainly a singleton, so Dufurat could be reasonably sure about the distribution. She discarded a diamond on the ace of spades and ruffed dummy's remaining spade, cashed

NORTH		WEST		EAST	
♠ A 3	♠ Q 10 9 8 7 5 2	♠ K J 6 4	♠ K J 10 8 6	♠ K J 6 4	♠ K J 10 8 6
♥ K 9 7 4 3	♥ 2	♥ Q J 10 8 6	♥ Q J 10 8 6	♥ Q J 10 8 6	♥ Q J 10 8 6
♦ A 10 5 3	♦ Q 9	♦ J 8 6	♦ J 8 6	♦ J 8 6	♦ J 8 6
♣ A 10	♣ K 6 4	♣ 7	♣ 7	♣ 7	♣ 7
SOUTH		WEST		EAST	
♠ Void	♠ Void	♠ Void	♠ Void	♠ Void	♠ Void
♥ A 5	♥ A 5	♥ A 5	♥ A 5	♥ A 5	♥ A 5
♦ K 7 4 2	♦ K 7 4 2	♦ K 7 4 2	♦ K 7 4 2	♦ K 7 4 2	♦ K 7 4 2
♣ Q J 9 8 5 3 2	♣ Q J 9 8 5 3 2	♣ Q J 9 8 5 3 2	♣ Q J 9 8 5 3 2	♣ Q J 9 8 5 3 2	♣ Q J 9 8 5 3 2

The bidding:
SOUTH 1♣
WEST 3♣
NORTH Dbl*
EAST 4♠
All pass
*Negative

Opening lead: Two of ♥

her two high diamonds, and led a club to West. She ruffed the forced spade return and started to run her clubs. This was the position with one club left to cash:

She cashed her club and discarded a diamond from dummy. East was finished. Whatever East discarded would allow Dufurat to take the last two tricks. Beautifully played!

NORTH		WEST		EAST	
♠ Void	♠ 10 9 8	♠ 10 9 8	♠ 10 9 8	♠ Void	♠ Void
♥ K 9	♥ Void	♥ Void	♥ Void	♥ Q J	♥ Q J
♦ 10	♦ Void	♦ Void	♦ Void	♦ J	♦ J
♣ Void	♣ Void	♣ Void	♣ Void	♣ Void	♣ Void
SOUTH		WEST		EAST	
♠ Void	♠ Void	♠ Void	♠ Void	♠ Void	♠ Void
♥ 5	♥ 5	♥ 5	♥ 5	♥ 5	♥ 5
♦ 7	♦ 7	♦ 7	♦ 7	♦ 7	♦ 7
♣ 5	♣ 5	♣ 5	♣ 5	♣ 5	♣ 5

QUIZ Easy like Sunday morning

Eponym things



Ygnacio Martínez was a Californian rancher after whom the city of Martinez was named. Which popular cocktail got its name from this town? (GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK)

Berty Ashley

Born on May 31, 1852, Julius Richard was a German microbiologist who, while working for Robert Koch, invented the device that is now named after him. In the lab, his job was to culture and purify bacterial colonies. What device did he invent that has become central to the study of microbes?

Joseph was an English surgeon who while working in Glasgow introduced a system that helped bring down the number of deaths. He used carbolic acid to sterilise instruments and hands. This led to which American antiseptic mouthwash being named in his honour?

Ernst was an Austrian physicist who studied shock waves. He used photographs to show that bullets travelled faster than the speed of sound. This led to what quantity in fluid dynamics being named after him?

of Savoy, the Queen of Italy, visited Naples in 1889. To commemorate her visit, chef Raffaele Esposito supposedly created a new dish using a red tomato, white mozzarella, and green basil to represent the Italian flag. Till date, by what name is this dish known as?

Ygnacio Martínez was a Californian rancher after whom the city of Martinez was named. Legend has it that either a bartender in that town created

this popular cocktail, or that it was served to people going there, hence the name. What is this drink made famous by a fictional British secret service agent?

This toy gets its name from the nickname of Theodore Roosevelt, the 26th president of the United States. The name comes from a hunting incident in which he refused to shoot an animal that had been tied up. What is the toy?

This popular 3D puzzle is named after Hungarian professor of architecture, Ernő, who devised it after seeing water move around pebbles by the River Danube. Who was this who said, "Complex things, if you don't understand them, it seems

complicated. If you understand them, and we know how to handle it, it becomes simple."?

Haile Selassie was the emperor of Ethiopia for 44 years from 1930. His birth name was Ras Tafari Makonnen, with 'Ras' being a title akin to 'prince'. During his reign, a new Abrahamic religion evolved, and it also popularised the musical genre, Reggae. What is this religion known as?

Homo thalensis is an extinct group of humans who lived about 40,000 years ago. The name comes from the valley in Germany where the first specimen with a long skull and wide chest was found. The area itself gets its name from Joachim who was a local pastor in the 17th century. What was his name and the species?

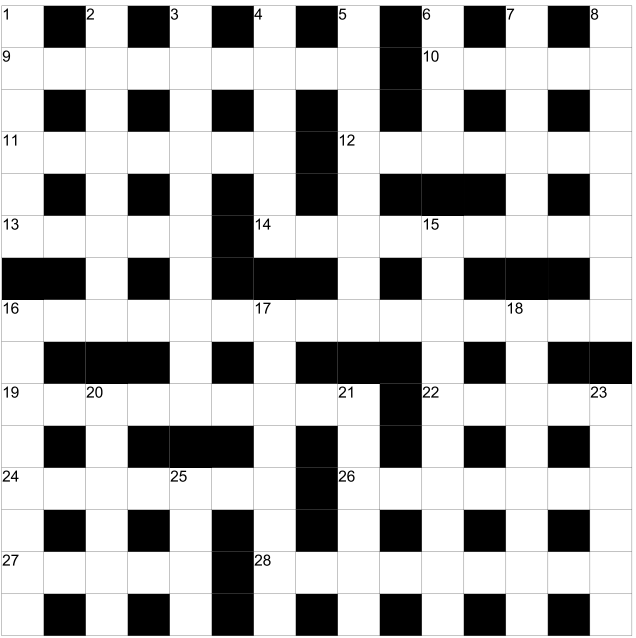
In 1979, French Finance minister Étienne de imposed severe economic demands on the citizens because of the Seven Years' War. His name became synonymous with anything done cheaply, especially with portraits. What was his name?

A molecular biologist from Madurai, our quizmaster enjoys trivia and music, and is working on a rock ballad called 'Coffee is a Drink, Kaapi is an Emotion'. @bertyashley

1. Petr, Petr dish
2. Lister, Listerine
3. Mach, Mach number
4. Margherita, Pizza Margherita
5. Martini
6. Teddy bear
7. Erno Rubik, he invented the Rubik's Cube
8. Rastafarianism
9. Neanderthal
10. Silhouette

Answers

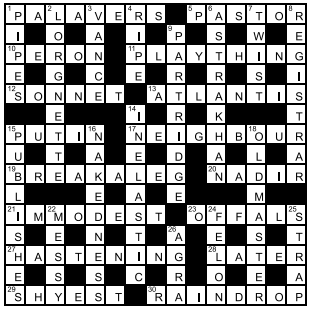
THE HINDU SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 58 (Set by Gussalufz)



- ACROSS**
- 1 Herb tea with spies breaking double agent (9)
 - 10 In the morning, milk please (5)
 - 11 They chop legs, go berserk arresting — right? (7)
 - 12 Nothing about finest American army character? (7)
 - 13 Trunk calls finally going through to Romania (5)
 - 14 Batter's strategy: turn hand, deftly clipping one (3-3-3)
 - 16 Artist going ahead sans wife (post-retirement party), boarding shortly, departing from Ivory Coast (8,2,5)
 - 19 Spray fizzy blue sticky stuff around and around (9)
 - 22 Giant beast regularly seen in tourist destinations (5)
 - 24 Mug delivered comfort (7)
 - 26 Champion bandages strained back to get going (7)
 - 27 Almost without question, ultimately primitive (5)
 - 28 Talk fondly about politician—nationalist steeped in revolutionary X factor (9)

- 5 Returning to chaps beaten in love (8)
- 6 Terminal transformation that converts a male into a mate? (4)
- 7 Extremely bored by quiet meal (6)
- 8 A lot of brothels in Kiev city (8)
- 15 Winning title, terrible tsar rejected guidance (10)
- 16 After digestion, meaningless to avoid blasting gas: court judges (8)
- 17 Underworld's grand rivalry creating scandal (8)
- 18 Admitting shell shock over weirdos (8)
- 20 Rhombic or noodle-shaped boxing headgear (6)
- 21 Charity supporting religious education zones (6)
- 23 Yes, women at dances like your gym body (6)
- 25 After shedding pounds, just ten stone (4)

SOLUTION NO. 57



This land is YOUR LAND

Woody Guthrie’s music rises again today not as longing but as foresight. It tells us that borders cannot erase memory, and that those cast out will always find their song

Shelley Walia
shelleywalia@gmail.com

It was last year around the rainy season that I stumbled upon the previously unreleased Woody Guthrie songs from the 1950s. Recorded in the early 1950s, these songs return to a world still struggling with the same moral questions of migrants, war, displacement, and social justice that Guthrie wrote about with such compassion. Their re-emergence is a reminder that history’s unresolved injustices continue to echo across generations.

Listening to those recordings, I felt a strange tug of recognition, as if a voice from my boyhood had resurfaced to speak again in a world grown darker, racist, and more divided. Woody Guthrie, one of America’s most influential folk singers and songwriters, was always there in the background of my growing years. I remember him for giving voice to the homeless, turning their suffering and resilience into songs of extraordinary moral force, particularly his song, *This Land Is Your Land*. But hearing his “undiscovered” music now, at this fraught moment in history, struck me differently. Guthrie, in one of those underground songs, imagines Fred Trump (Donald’s father) “stirring up racial hate ... when he drewed that color line ... at his ... family project”. His words, buried for decades, resonate in today’s dismal Trumpian world as warning against postwar American landlord capitalism that is characteristically exclusionary and continues into the present.

I recall, as an undergraduate, being fascinated by Guthrie’s ability to turn simple chords into plaintive melody. He now takes me back to my personal history of growing up in times when we also listened to Pete Seeger, Bob Dylan, Simon and Garfunkel, voices that taught us, before we quite had the words for it, that music and meaning were inseparable, and that a song could carry the weight of an entire world’s conscience. I believe his music speaks to this moment, to the fractured times we find ourselves in, the ethnic wars, the sectarian upheavals, the casual brutalities that have come to feel almost routine. These were precisely the



warnings we did not listen carefully enough. To me, his songs were munitions, scratched on battered guitars with the words *This Machine Kills Fascists*. Even then, before I could fully grasp their politics, I sensed they belonged to farmers cast off their land, to workers standing hungry before locked warehouses, to migrants carrying their children into uncertain futures. And I recalled Guthrie’s line, “*Nobody living can ever stop me, / As I go walking my freedom highway*,” a declaration that no wall, no border, no fear should stop people yearning for belonging. And perhaps that is why Guthrie returned to me in the wake of last year’s floods in Punjab. Water spilling across our villages carried me back to stories of the rivers before Partition, when the Sutlej and Ravi flowed freely through lands where Sikhs, Hindus, and Muslims lived together without suspicion. My elders spoke of a Punjab unscarred by borders, where land was not yet divided by barbed wire or hatred. Partition changed that forever. Fields were abandoned, neighbours lost, memory scarred. Listening to Guthrie today, I realise that Partition was a moment when people were uprooted not by wind and sand, but by politics and the cruelty of a line drawn on a map.

No deed, no fence
At the heart of Guthrie’s vision was the conviction that land belongs to no deed and no fence; it is made, as he sang , for you and me. It was no saccharine patriotic hymn but a radical critique of exclusion, of “No Trespassing” signs, and of hungry people staring at locked doors of plenty. I cannot help hearing those words today in the cries of

Palestinians, exiled from olive groves and ancestral soil. I see farmers in Ukraine anguished with their fields turned to rubble, their homes occupied. Even in America itself, the land Guthrie sang for, the contradiction has never been sharper. Immigration policies under Trump continue to create a climate of fear and trauma lacking in basic humanitarian sensitivity. Migrants who harvest the fields, build the cities, and care for the children are vilified as intruders. Trump’s America has perfected this cruelty by ripping families apart, caging children, turning back asylum seekers. And across his recordings the refrain still echoes: “*Ain’t got no home in this world anymore*.” As I listened to those “new” Guthrie songs, I felt they were not relics but summons. They reminded me that music, like rivers, resists partitions. It flows across generations, carrying memory and defiance. Just as the Punjab floods remind us that water does not obey borders, Guthrie’s music reminds us that art cannot be silenced and that music has its own ways of seeping through borders at the right time and the right place. And I recognise, in today’s refugees and migrants, the same stubborn endurance Guthrie sang of, the refusal to disappear, the insistence on belonging. Woody Guthrie’s music rises again today not as longing but as foresight. It tells us that borders cannot erase memory, and that those cast out will always find their song. As Lebanon burns, as Ukraine bleeds, as immigrants are told to leave lands they have laboured to build, Guthrie whispers across time: “This land is not theirs to hoard. It belongs to the people, in their struggle and their hope.”

Roads are dark and rough for women drivers

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My mother loves to drive her car, because it had always been her dream to learn driving. She had to fulfil her dream after much initial resistance from the family, because she is a woman. She has been driving for years now and is confident behind the wheel. But a woman driving a car is still considered an unusual spectacle. When mom is driving and I am in the passenger seat, I often see male drivers looking at her with scorn, contempt, and ridicule. The road does not discriminate based on gender, neither does the car, but people do. Every day, I keep on finding instances of the prejudice against women drivers.

Once, a boy parked his car alongside ours on the parking lot and stepped inside a supermarket. My mother told him politely, “You forgot to turn off the headlights. The battery of the car may drain out.” He laughed. Would he have laughed if the suggestion was offered to him by a man? It reminded me of the time when the same suggestion was offered to my mother by a man. He had uttered the same words, albeit with scorn, contempt, and ridicule. If men make mistakes while driving, it is considered normal. When they block the road to reverse their cars, the other drivers wait for them patiently, without blowing their horns. If a woman does it, it’s blasphemy. Horns are blown. Heads are shaken. Rebuffs are uttered. Sometimes, this prejudice takes the form of road rage. We were stuck in a traffic jam. The neighbouring car intentionally hit ours and its driver laughed. Would he have dared to do the same, if our car was being driven by my father?

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A recent injury to the lateral collateral ligament, and the sudden inability to do things without a second thought, made me pause. As a long-distance runner, I had always taken movement for granted. The knee was simply there, doing its job quietly. I had injured the same knee once before. It healed in eight weeks with a brace. Back then, all I knew was this: keep the knee mobile, keep it strong, and life goes on. I never thought beyond that. This recent injury made me reflect on an important truth: awareness builds life’s foundation, but, awareness is also about timing. The same event can happen at two different stages of life and leave two different meanings. My first knee injury gave me recovery. This one gave me reflection. Wisdom is often around us, but we receive it only when we are ready. As we grow, something within us matures. Our inner receivers become better tuned. We begin to understand lessons hidden inside ordinary moments. Wisdom can arrive in many forms, a setback, a conversation with a friend, a line in a newspaper, a social media post, a passing remark, a quiet morning. The message may always be there. Readiness decides whether it enters us. Readiness is a function

Recovery, reflection, and the larger truth

A knee injury sparks a conversation within oneself, teaching the importance of self-awareness



ISTOCK/GETTY IMAGES

of the mind becoming calm enough to observe. A calm mind sees what a restless mind misses. When we slow down enough to notice what is happening within and around us, we begin asking better questions. Many saw the apple fall. One man asked why. Curiosity, not mere observation, changes lives. **Reactive, not reflective** Modern life pushes us into thousands of decisions every day. Big ones, small ones, trivial ones. Over time, the mind gets crowded. We become reactive instead of reflective. We respond quickly, but not always wisely. This is why calmness matters. A calmer mind sharpens judgment. It helps us separate noise from signal, urgency from

importance, fear from fact. And calmness often begins with something very basic: breathing. We breathe every moment, yet rarely pay attention to it. But the moment we consciously observe and steady our breath, something changes internally. Breath influences the nervous system, the body’s communication network that governs thought, emotion, movement, and response. During a morning run recently, I was moving almost effortlessly when a passing vehicle made an unusual sound. In a fraction of a second, my body changed. Muscles tightened. Attention sharpened. My stride adjusted. The ancient fight-or-flight system had activated before conscious thought even arrived.

Then, just as quickly, awareness and conscious breathing took over. The breath steadied. The body understood there was no danger. Calm returned. All in a few seconds. That is the wisdom of the body. It is always listening. This should be the wisdom of the mind, always aware. When we understand these inner shifts, we gain power. Conscious breathing becomes a form of communication back to the nervous system. It tells the body that not every alarm is a threat. Stress then becomes temporary and useful, instead of chronic and damaging. This kind of awareness does not stop with health. It extends into identity. Many people live in quiet dependence on approval, wanting to be seen, validated, praised, accepted. But self-awareness lets you meet yourself honestly. You see clearly what you are, what you are not, what you know, and what you need to learn. There is freedom in that honesty. What you have, you value. What you lack, you build. What you do not know, you approach with curiosity rather than insecurity. It changes leadership too. A self-aware leader becomes less defensive and more empathetic. They listen better. They consider angles beyond their own. They understand that decisions affect human beings, not just numbers. Sometimes life uses discomfort to get our attention. Not to break us, but to awaken us. And often, what first appears as pain is simply wisdom.



FEEDBACK

Letters to the *Magazine* can be e-mailed separately to mag.letters@thehindu.co.in by Tuesday 3 p.m.

Cover story

The cover story is a reminder to every book lover or someone just starting their reading journey, to not view the physical purchase of a book as a one-time read but as a reminder to share them with everyone around them. (‘Is it India’s bookstore moment?’; May 24) The temptation of online prices is understandable but it does not stand a chance against the experience of walking through a bookstore and taking the time to carefully curate your next read.

Jasreet Kaur

While literary events, author interactions, and café models may generate visibility and goodwill, they alone cannot make the business viable. Without structural support and fairer market conditions, opening an independent bookstore today remains an extremely risky proposition, especially for new entrants.

Poorna

A big win

Yang Shuang-zi’s win is a reminder that literary fiction need not sacrifice formal ambition for accessibility. (‘*Taiwan Travelogue* wins Int’l Booker’; May 24) That a novel originally in Mandarin, with footnotes and layered narrative, can reach global readers speaks well of what serious translation can achieve. Prize culture alone won’t fix this, but visibility helps.

M. Barathi

Through the lens

S.R. Praveen’s account rightly situates early Malayalam cinema within

Kerala’s social reform movements rather than treating it as mere entertainment history. (‘Beginnings of Malayalam cinema’; May 24) The connection between caste, leftist politics and storytelling is rarely made explicit in popular film discourse. This deserves more attention, especially in an age where streaming platforms increasingly dictate what gets made.

Pon Arun Kumar

Co-existence is key

The cockroach has predated the dinosaur. (‘Pista and the cockroach’; May 24) In ancient Persia, pistachios were a symbol of wealth and luck, and time immemorial, cockroaches have been known for their adaptability. The writer has brought in the idea of co-existence of the cockroach and pista in the same ecosystem subtly.

Beena Anil

Forgotten history

Devdutt Pattanaik’s piece on the Barabar caves draws attention to a site that receives far less scholarly and tourist interest than it deserves. (‘Secrets of Bihar’s mirrored caves’; May 24) The Ajivika connection is particularly under-explored in mainstream historical narratives, which tend to centre Buddhism and Jainism.

S.M. Jeeva

Correction

The headline of the *Magazine* article dated May 24, 2026, should have read ‘*Taiwan Travelogue* wins Int’l Booker’ and not as mentioned. The error is regretted.
— Editor



MORE ON THE WEB

www.thehindu.com/opinion/open-page

Chennai by cycle

Exploring the city on two wheels with pedal power
Srikumar K.S.

There is much in a name

For women, their name is not the primary marker of identity but a shifting label dependent on male association
Stuti Tripathi

Soft glow

Breathing in kerosene and exhaling warmth, the lantern did not merely light the path; it lingered, it listened, it loved
Ritu Kamra Kumar

Living a full life

Spare the elderly from talk of age-related health crises or impending doom
Sigamani Vasudevan

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